

GEOPOLITICAL — UKRAINE · THEMATIC

The Lever Board

Which Western levers actually move the priced odds of a Ukraine-favorable outcome, what does each cost — and why does the market price nearly all of them as un-pulled?

TON618 CAPITAL RESEARCH · POLYMARKET MARKS AS OF 24 AUGUST 2026

PATH A — THE TABLE



PATH B — THE FIELD



THE BOARD, IN ONE PARAGRAPH

Fifty-one percent talk. Fourteen and a half sign.

The market prices peace talks by year-end at 51% and a signed peace deal at 14.5% — a 1-in-3.5 conversion — and prices every deliberate Western lever that could raise that conversion below 10%, while pricing an *involuntary* NATO–Russia clash at 26.5%. The revealed expectation is drift: pressure rising, no lever pulled to completion, the war grinding through the Kostiantynivka–Druzhkivka line (both ~52%) without breaking the Kramatorsk–Sloviansk belt (~28–33%) and without conquering Donetsk (2.9%). The settlement weight, meanwhile, has been moving toward terms Ukraine would call unfavorable: across the archived vintages since August 8, the deal-without-cession residual — the priced weight on a settlement without territorial concession — has compressed from 10 points to 4, driven by the deal leg falling (19.5% → 14.5% since 8/8) while the cession leg held its ground (10.0% → 10.5%, round-tripping through 6.5% on 8/22).

Fact vs. opinion, stated up front: every percentage in this note is a market price, not a house forecast. Where we interpret (“the market believes X”), the inference is stated and testable. The house takes no side in this war; “Ukraine-favorable outcome” is used throughout as a defined, priceable basket, not an endorsement.

Defining the outcome so it can be priced. A Ukraine-favorable outcome = a ceasefire or settlement **without** the concession legs — no territorial cession (10.5%), no armed-forces cap (7.0%), no forced NATO renunciation (7.0%) — **plus** a real security guarantee (US 8.5% / any European state 7.0%). On today's board the deal-without-cession residual is roughly **4 points** (deal 14.5% minus cede 10.5%, treating cession as a subset of deals) — down from ~7 points two days ago.

 THE OTHER SIDE FIRST

The case for the holstered hand, in its strongest form

The strongest case against pulling the levers is not timidity. It is that the unpulled board may be *correctly priced restraint*:

1. **The escalation ledger is asymmetric.** The market prices a NATO×Russia military clash by 12/31 at **26.5%** — already the highest-probability contract on the entire board. Every coercion lever (deep-strike enablement, shadow-fleet interdiction, troops) raises that number before it raises any peace leg. A rational coalition treats 26.5% as a budget constraint, not a curiosity.
2. **Asset seizure has a stated, credible cost.** The objection to seizing (rather than immobilizing) ~\$300B of Russian sovereign assets is not Russian propaganda; it is the on-record position of the ECB and of Euroclear's home governments — that outright seizure risks euro-reserve credibility and invites reciprocal expropriation of Western assets in Russia. The G7 answer to date — lending against windfall profits (\$50B ERA framework) rather than touching principal — is a designed compromise, not an oversight.
3. **Coalition blockers are observable and priced.** Unanimity requirements, standing veto players within the EU, and a US political cycle that has already produced repeated aid interruptions (a full suspension and at least

two shipment pauses in 2025 alone) are public facts. The market pricing the guarantee legs at 7–8.5% may simply be reading the voting arithmetic correctly.

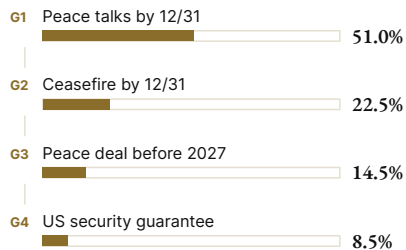
4. **The levers may not convert.** Sanctions since 2022 have re-routed Russian oil more than they have de-funded it; a coerced counterpart at the table is not a signing counterpart (talks 51% vs. deal 14.5% *is* that argument, priced); and history's record of economic pressure producing territorial withdrawal by a nuclear power is thin. The mirror case deserves its own strongest form: sub-10% pull odds may price political will, not lever efficacy — an un-pulled board tests nothing about what a pulled lever would do.
5. **What this note cannot test within its frame:** whether restraint itself is what keeps the clash contract at 26.5% rather than higher — i.e., whether the un-pulled board is the *cause* of the ceiling on escalation risk. The ladder cannot separate that counterfactual, and we say so. A second structural cap, cutting the other way: the ladder ends 12/31/2026. A lever whose payoff arrives in 2027+ — the guarantee, co-production at scale — cannot register on this board at all; low year-end pull odds are evidence about political will inside the window, not about lever efficacy. Of the four numbered arguments above, the note's analysis tests #1 and #4 against the term structure; #2 (seizure cost) and #3 (coalition arithmetic) are taken as stated and not re-litigated here.

The test that follows must beat this case, not a weaker one.

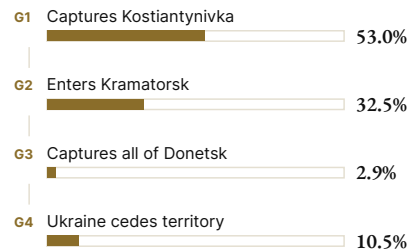
Two paths, each a chain of gates, every gate a live contract

EXHIBIT 1 The two-path probability ladder — gates G1–G4, Polymarket, 24 Aug 2026

PATH A — COERCED SETTLEMENT



PATH B — BATTLEFIELD SETTLEMENT



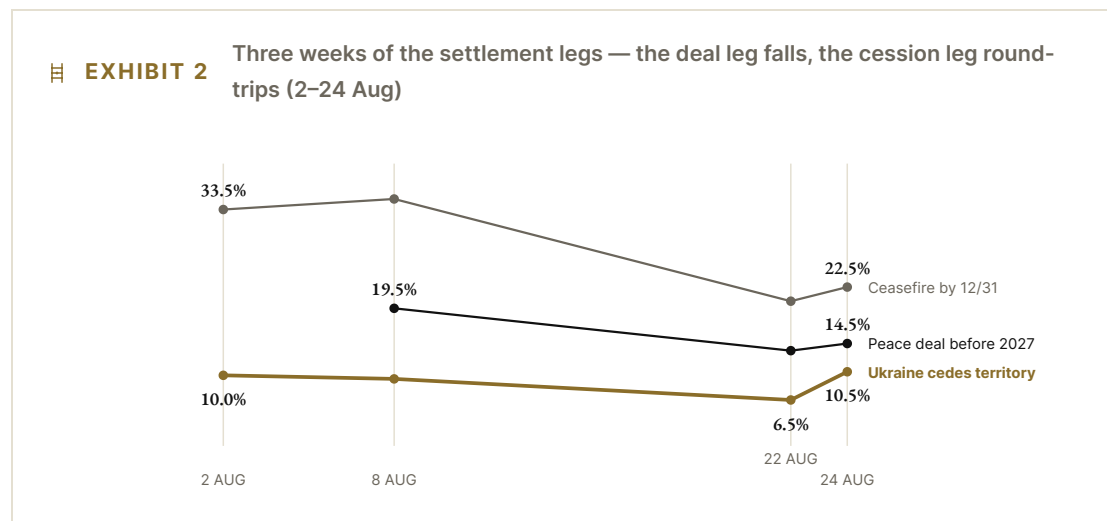
Bars are Polymarket probabilities, 24 Aug 2026. Each path is a chain: the mass that dies between rungs is the story.

Alongside the charted gates: on Path A, talks by 9/30 print 11%, ceasefire by 10/31 8.5%, and a Putin–Zelensky meeting 6.5% (93.5% “never meet”); a European guarantee 7.0%. On Path B, Russia entering Dobropillia prints 88.5% (near-done), Druzhkivka 51.5%, Sloviansk-enter 27.5% (capture 7.0%), Lyman 34.5%, Kupiansk 27.5%; the terms rungs — give up the rest of Donbas 4.2%, cap the armed forces 7.0%, forswear NATO 7.0%. Three reads fall out of the ladder:

READ 1 **Talks ≠ deal.** 51% for talks, 22.5% for a ceasefire, 14.5% for a signed deal: the market’s central case is a meeting that does not close. Conditional on talks occurring, a deal converts at roughly **28%**. Path A’s gate 1 is open; gate 2 is where the probability mass dies.

READ 2 **The settlement, as priced, is drifting toward Path B’s terms — but the driver is the deal leg falling, not the cession leg rising.** Across the archived vintages the deal-without-cession residual has compressed from **10.0 points** (8/8: deal 19.5% – cede 9.5%) to **7.0** (8/22) to **4.0** (8/24). The three-week view disciplines the 48-hour one: the cession leg’s two-day jump (6.5% → 10.5%, on a \$712k book — not thin) is a *round-trip* back to its early-August level (10.0% on 8/2), while the durable moves are the deal leg falling 19.5% → 14.5% and the year-end ceasefire leg falling 35% → 22.5%. Either way the arithmetic lands in the same place: of the settlements the market still prices, the share involving territorial cession has risen from roughly half (8/8) to roughly three-quarters (8/24). Our pre-registered reversal tell — cession outrunning the deal leg — fired on the 48-hour window; the three-week series says the squeeze is coming from

the deal side, and the cession signal stays unconfirmed until the 8/31 strip resolves.



READ 3 The battlefield feeds the table; it does not close the war. Cession at 10.5% against Donetsk-conquest at 2.9% means the market prices any concession as *negotiated*, not imposed — Russia cannot take the land it would be ceded, on these odds. Path B, as priced, is a pressure lever on Path A's gate 4, not an independent road to an ending.

The lever board

EXHIBIT 3 The lever board — contracts and tells · 24 Aug 2026

SEVEN LEVERS, ALL IN THE OFF POSITION



Three reads, one question left standing: who can move these gates? Seven things Western allies could do; the gate each moves; what each costs; and the market's price on it being pulled.

#	LEVER	GATE IT MOVES	COST — THE REAL ONE
1	The money. Move from immobilizing ~\$300B of Russian sovereign assets (majority at Euroclear) to spending it — beyond the G7's \$50B windfall-profits loan framework already flowing	Funds levers 4 and 6 at scale; extends Kyiv's fiscal clock past Moscow's — pressure on A-gate 2	Euro-reserve credibility (the ECB's own stated objection); reciprocal seizure of Western assets in Russia; EU unanimity
2	Deep-strike enablement. Long-range weapons release + targeting support → the refinery and fuel-logistics campaign	A-gate 2: the coercion lever with a measurable bite	Escalation budget (the 26.5% clash contract is the price tag); marginal dollar cost trivial

#	LEVER	GATE IT MOVES	COST — THE REAL ONE
3	Sanctions escalation. Shadow-fleet interdiction; secondary measures on buyers of Russian crude	A-gate 2, jointly with lever 2	Oil-price and inflation passthrough to Western consumers; tanker- market dislocation (INSW, FRO and TNK at or near 52-week highs; STNG ~10% below its high)
4	Industrial co-production. The EU €1.1B drone package; the Danish build- in-Ukraine model; de- risking the deep dependency on Chinese- dominated component supply chains documented by RUSI and CSIS	Holds B-gates 1–2 shut: Kostiantynivka– Kramatorsk is a drone-wall problem	Modest in money; the binding constraint is components, not money
5	A security guarantee. The lever that voids Russia's outlast theory — if the West is committed past any ceasefire, waiting stops paying	Terminal gate, both paths; the single highest-value lever on the board	A contingent liability of near-Article-5 weight; the one lever that cannot be un-pulled
6	Air defense for the industrial base. Protects lever 4's factories and the grid they run on	B-gate blocker	Interceptor scarcity; adverse cost-exchange vs. cheap strike drones
7	Boots / the NATO path.	Terminal	The full escalation budget

The exhibit's one-line finding: every lever the market can price directly sits below 10%, and the only contract above 25% among the seven levers' direct contracts is the one nobody chooses. (The wider ladder has higher legs — talks 51%, territorial rungs to 88.5% — but none of them is a Western choice.) The market's revealed expectation is drift — sustain, pressure at the margin, pull

nothing to completion. The prices show what the crowd expects the West to do, not what the West prefers.

The exception that proves the mechanism: the one lever pair demonstrably in use is 2/3 — coercion at the margin. Its signature sits in the term structure — ceasefire mass parked in Q4 (1.6% by 8/31 → 8.5% → 22.5%) — read with care: cumulative contracts price higher at longer horizons mechanically, so the signal is not the upward slope itself but the pairing of a 51% talks leg with a 22.5% year-end ceasefire leg, and the fact that the 12/31 ceasefire leg has *fallen* from 35% on 8/8 while the talks leg sits at 51% (steady across the two vintages archived for it). Pressure is working *on the meeting*, not yet *on the signing* — and the 8/22→8/24 cession move suggests the market thinks the signing, if forced, now tilts toward Moscow's terms.

26.5%

The only contract above 25% on the seven-lever board is a NATO–Russia military clash by December 31 — the one outcome nobody chooses, priced above every outcome someone could.

THE PARTITION

Four endings, one year — as the market prices them

SCENARIO (BY 12/31/2026)	PROB.	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	THE TELL THAT CONFIRMS IT
Grind — no ceasefire (base)	~77.5%	Talks likely occur (51%) and stall; Kostiantynivka/Druzhkivka contested or taken (~52%); Kramatorsk–Sloviansk holds; levers stay at current settings	Ceasefire legs flat, territorial mid-ladder rungs rising

SCENARIO (BY 12/31/2026)	PROB.	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	THE TELL THAT CONFIRMS IT
Ceasefire, unsigned	~8%	Ceasefire (22.5%) without a signed deal (14.5%) — a freeze that formalizes nothing	Ceasefire leg converges up toward the talks leg
Settlement on mixed / Moscow-tilted terms	~10.5%	Deal with territorial cession; force caps / NATO renunciation possible (7% each)	Cession leg keeps outrunning the deal leg (the late-August pattern, extended)
Settlement, Ukraine-favorable	~4%	Deal <i>without</i> cession, plus a guarantee (8.5% / 7.0%)	Guarantee legs reprice above 20% first — they are the leading indicator
<i>Overlay (not exclusive):</i> NATO×Russia clash	26.5%	Can land inside any row above	10/31 leg (14.5%) is the near tripwire

Expected-value framing for any portfolio is out of scope by design: this note prices *outcomes*. The probabilities partition ($77.5 + 8 + 10.5 + 4 = 100$) under the stated assumption that cession occurs only inside a signed deal; the risk section takes that assumption back up.

🚩 HONEST LANDING

Where this read is weakest

1. **Thin books on the territorial mid-ladder.** Kramatorsk \$53k, Sloviansk-enter \$63k, Kupiansk-capture \$22k. Thin rungs are flagged ± 5 pts and never carry a conclusion alone. The legs the conclusions actually rest on are deep:

ceasefire-12/31 \$2.2M, deal \$2.6M, cede \$712k, clash-12/31 \$1.6M, NATO membership \$1.2M.

2. **Polymarket resolution risk.** “Enter/capture” contracts resolve on adjudicated map sources; disputes at the margin are possible. Date-bounded Kalshi twins, where they exist, are the cross-check.
3. **The 48-hour cession move could be noise or a single large trader.** It is flagged as an early tell, not a confirmed regime change; confirmation requires the pattern holding through the 8/31 strip resolution.
4. **Attention bias.** Polymarket’s book skews to Western participants; a systematically pro-Kyiv or pro-drift bias in the crowd cannot be excluded and is not correctable from inside the data.
5. **Model risk in the residual arithmetic.** “Deal minus cede = coerced-settlement weight” assumes cession only occurs inside a deal; a unilateral-freeze-with-de-facto-cession outcome would break that identity.

└ THE READOUT

What the board says to the hands on the levers

A conclusion is owed, and the board’s own arithmetic supplies one — read as prices, not policy advice; the house holds no side, and every claim below is conditional on the objective being the Ukraine-favorable basket as this note defined it.

Are the levers under-utilized? The board cannot answer that directly — it prices political will, not lever efficacy (the steelman’s second untestable). But it supports three precise statements. *First*, the only levers in visible use are the coercion pair (2/3), and their yield is flattening: enough pressure to convene a meeting (talks 51%) but not to close one (deal 14.5% — down net from 19.5% over three weeks, though up 1.0pt in the latest 48 hours). *Second*, every deliberate lever is priced below 10% while the involuntary outcome — a NATO–Russia clash — is priced at 26.5%: drift is not the risk-free path; it already carries the board’s single largest risk. *Third*, the 4-point Ukraine-favorable residual is, mechanically, a priced bet that the terminal levers stay holstered.

Which levers, ranked by probability moved per unit of escalation risk — on this board’s arithmetic:

1. **Industrial co-production and air defense (levers 4/6) are the cheapest probability on the board.** They move no peace leg directly, but they are what holds Path B's gates shut — and the market already credits them (Donetsk conquest 2.9% against a 53% Kostiantynivka leg). Their binding risk is industrial (the component chain), not escalatory.
2. **The security guarantee (lever 5) is the highest-value single pull.** It is the terminal gate on both paths — the only lever whose pull would reprice every downstream leg at once, which is exactly why the reversal section names the guarantee legs the leading indicator. Its cost is a contingent liability, not a present escalation; its risk is that it cannot be un-pulled.
3. **The coercion pair (levers 2/3) is working at diminishing returns.** Demonstrated bite, measurable tells — and each further increment spends against the 26.5% clash budget while the deal leg keeps falling.
4. **The money (lever 1) has a proven de-risked pattern.** The ERA structure showed a low-risk tranche of the lever can be pulled — profits, not principal — without triggering the seizure objections. The remaining ~\$300B principal is the untested rest of that lever, and the steelman's seizure-cost case stands against it unrebutted here.
5. **Boots (lever 7) is dominated on this board.** Near lever 5's terminal effect at a strictly higher escalation cost; the market prices it accordingly (5.2%).

The one lesson that does not depend on which side of the steelman is right: as priced, the West is currently paying escalation risk without buying probability on any peace leg — a 26.5% clash contract alongside a falling deal leg is the board's worst quadrant. Moving out of it in *either* direction — pulling a terminal lever, or genuinely de-escalating — buys something the current posture does not. Drift buys nothing and still pays the premium — unless restraint itself is what holds the clash leg at 26.5% rather than higher (the steelman's first untestable), in which case drift is buying the ceiling; that is the one reading this lesson cannot rule out. Whether the exit should run through lever 5 or through restraint is the choice this note prices but does not make.

The honest residual — the case in which no lever suffices. Every ranking above assumes Moscow's binding constraint is strategic: costs weighed against aims. If it is instead regime-internal — if the war economy, mobilization politics, and elite structure now require the war itself — then no terms clear, the tolerate-versus-fight comparison never binds, and the grind is not a failure to settle but the

objective. The market's **77.5%** no-ceasefire base case, sitting beside a deal leg that has fallen net for three weeks and a talks leg steady at 51% in our archive, is arguably that reading, priced. On that view the levers' realistic product is not a settlement at all — it is a cheaper, more stable stalemate: Path B's gates held shut at declining cost, escalation risk contained, Ukraine's de facto security built without anyone's signature. That is a lesser goal than peace, and this note names it as the one the base case actually pays out.

🔗 THE SPECULATION — LABELED AS SUCH

If the board had to move: the sequence the arithmetic suggests

Everything above is a reading of prices. What follows is the house's *conditional speculation* beyond what prices alone establish — opinion, labeled as opinion, still conditional on the Ukraine-favorable basket being the objective, and still owing the steelman its due: the restraint reading of this same board would sequence nothing and negotiate now. With that stated, the arithmetic implies an order, and the order has a logic: **buy probability before spending risk, and pull reversible levers before irreversible ones.**

1. **First — the no-regret tier: scale levers 4 and 6, funded through lever 1's proven tranche.** Co-production and air defense spend no escalation budget, are scalable and reversible, and hold Path B's gates shut — which is what keeps the battlefield feeding the table instead of replacing it. The ERA pattern (profits, not principal) already showed how to fund this without triggering the seizure objections. Why first: every later lever works better from behind a holding line, and none of this forecloses a single future choice.
2. **Second — re-point lever 5: the West's guarantee to Ukraine activates at signing, not before it.** To be precise about who gets what: the guarantee is to Kyiv, from the West — Russia gets nothing except certainty about what signing buys. The mechanism is two-sided, and honesty requires both halves. For Kyiv, this is what makes a deal signable at all: an unguaranteed freeze is a rearmament pause, and that constraint — not only Moscow's reluctance — is a candidate cause of the 1-in-3.5 talks-to-deal conversion. For Moscow, cutting the other way, a guarantee-at-signing *raises* the price of signing: it locks in a Western-committed Ukraine, which is exactly what Russia says it

fights to prevent. On its own, lever 5 re-pointed this way could therefore lower Moscow's willingness to close. It works only paired with the no-regret tier: with levers 4/6 compounding, *not* signing means facing an increasingly fortified, Western-industrialized Ukraine anyway — on a slower fuse, at continuing cost. The choice put to Moscow is a guaranteed Ukraine behind a frozen line now, or an effectively backed Ukraine later from a worse position — waiting stops paying in either branch, and that pairing, not the guarantee alone, is the outlast-killer. Structure: European tranche (7.0% leg) before US (8.5%), bilateral before treaty-grade; committed-if-signed is a different risk object than committed-now, which converts lever 5's worst property (irreversibility) into its point.

3. **Hold, don't increment — the coercion pair (2/3).** Maintain, don't add — the readout's arithmetic already made this case, and the marginal coercion dollar is better spent on the no-regret tier. Coercion's remaining job is not to win — it is to keep the price of waiting positive while levers 4/6 compound.
4. **Keep holstered — boots (7) and lever 1's principal.** Boots stays dominated by the guarantee at every point on this board. The ~\$300B principal stays where the steelman left it: the seizure case is unrebutted here, and the profits tranche is not yet exhausted.

Who signs what — the paradox and its resolution, with the market's confirming bids. An Article-5-style guarantee is the thing this war was launched to prevent; no pressure short of collapse makes Moscow *sign* one, because signing converts every cost paid since 2022 into strategic defeat regardless of territory held. The market prices that refusal as its deepest conviction on the board: NATO membership before 2027 at **3.3%** on a \$1.2M book. The resolution is that Russia's signature is required on the ceasefire line — not on the guarantee. Korea 1953 is the template: the armistice was signed with the adversary; the US-ROK Mutual Defense Treaty was signed with the ally, separately, just over two months later — the other side never consented to the treaty, only to the line.

In parallel papers, Moscow signs a freeze while the West signs the guarantee with Kyiv; Putin does not concede it — he *tolerates* it, as Moscow tolerated armed West Germany and armed South Korea. The face-saving decomposition even has its own leg on the board: Ukraine formally forswearing NATO *membership* is priced at **7.0%** while the bilateral guarantee legs sit at **8.5%** / **7.0%** — de jure neutrality alongside de facto commitment, each separately

priced, is a package the market treats as more likely than membership by a factor of two or more. And this is why the sequence leads with levers 4/6: they are the levers that need no Russian consent at all. A fortified, Western-industrialized Ukraine is the de facto guarantee, Russia holds no veto over it, and every month of grind builds the thing Moscow would be tolerating at signing anyway — the choice becomes acknowledging it from behind a frozen line now, or facing more of it from a worse position later. The template's limits are stated plainly: in 1953 the treaty's credibility was garrison-backed, and the adversary at the table was not the nuclear principal; here the de facto industrial guarantee substitutes for the garrison — an untested substitution, and the restraint case's strongest objection to this architecture.

The accelerant clause: this sequence assumes time is neutral. The reversal section says when it is not — if the cession leg keeps outrunning the deal leg through 9/30, the settlement being priced is drifting toward Moscow's terms, and the guarantee-at-signing move stops being a closing instrument and becomes the floor under Ukraine's negotiating position. In that branch it moves from second to first.

How we would be wrong: if the steelman's restraint case is right, step 2 reprices the clash leg before the deal leg and the sequence has spent the board's scarcest budget on its least certain mechanism. That is the bet, stated plainly — and tripwire 4 (clash clearing 35%) is where this speculation concedes.

THE TRIPWIRES

What would change our view

1. **Any single lever repricing above 20%** — the guarantee legs (8.5% / 7.0%) are the ones to watch; they are the terminal gate for both paths and would move every leg downstream.
2. **The cession leg continuing to outrun the deal leg** through 9/30 — that flips the board's meaning from "coercion working slowly" to "Ukraine's negotiating floor cracking," and the lever-board question inverts: the relevant levers become the ones that *stop* a Moscow-tilted settlement, not the ones that produce a settlement.
3. **Kramatorsk or Sloviansk-enter clearing 50%** — Path B's gate 2 open would mean the drone wall (levers 4/6) failed at its job, and the battlefield

would no longer be merely feeding the table.

4. **The clash contract clearing 35%** — the escalation budget consumed without a lever pulled; the steelman's restraint case would then be winning the argument on its own terms.

APPENDIX

Sources & method

Prediction markets. All probabilities and volumes from the Polymarket gamma API (`gamma-api.polymarket.com/public-search`), pulled 2026-08-22 and 2026-08-24 (both vintage and pull date; the two coincide for each vintage), volume floor \$20,000; both raw pulls archived unmodified at `data/data-ukraine-polymarket-2026-08-22.txt` and `data/pm_ukraine_2026-08-24.txt` in the note folder. Prices are each contract's first outcome ("Yes") price. Where near-duplicate contracts exist ("ceasefire" vs. "ceasefire agreement"; a misspelled "Dopropillia" twin) the deeper, correctly-specified book is used consistently: the "ceasefire agreement" series and the correctly-spelled Dobropillia contract. The 8/2 and 8/8 vintages in Exhibit 2 (ceasefire 12/31 33.5% / 35%; deal 19.5%; cede 10.0% / 9.5%) are from the house slates of those dates (`research-ideas/slate-2026-08-02.md`, `research-ideas/slate-2026-08-08.md`); the deal leg was not marked on 8/2. Kalshi date-bounded twins are the cross-check where they exist.

Derived figures, written out. Talks→deal conversion = $\text{deal}/\text{talks} = 14.5/51.0 \approx 28\%$. Deal-without-cession residual = $\text{deal} - \text{cede} = 19.5 - 9.5 = 10.0$ pts (8/8), $13.5 - 6.5 = 7.0$ pts (8/22), $14.5 - 10.5 = 4.0$ pts (8/24); cession share of priced deals = $\text{cede}/\text{deal} = 49\%$ (8/8) → 72% (8/24), under the stated assumption that cession occurs only inside a signed deal. Scenario partition: grind = $100 - 22.5$; ceasefire-unsigned = $22.5 - 14.5$; Moscow-tilted = 10.5 (the cede leg); Ukraine-favorable = the 4.0-pt residual. The Putin-Zelensky 6.5% is derived as $100 - 93.5$ (the "will not meet" leg). All are conditional arithmetic on market prices, not forecasts.

Institutional and policy facts. Immobilized Russian sovereign assets (~\$300B, majority at Euroclear) and the \$50B G7 Extraordinary Revenue Acceleration loan framework: G7 leaders' statements and Euroclear/ECB public commentary. ECB and Euroclear-home-government objections to outright seizure: on-record public statements. The EU €1.1B drone package and the Danish build-in-Ukraine procurement model: European Commission and Ukrainian Ministry of Defence releases. US aid interruptions in 2025 (one suspension, at least two shipment pauses): contemporaneous DoD statements and Congressional Research Service reporting.

Drone-industry sourcing hierarchy (assessed 2026-08-23). Tier 1 — official Ukrainian releases (NSDC scale figures; the Brave1 platform): deliberate state messaging, used for

structure and direction, never for output actuals. Tier 2 — RUSI (“Drones Win Battles, Components Win Wars”), CSIS drone supply-chain analysis, Kyiv School of Economics manufacturer surveys, Georgetown Security Studies Review: the analytical spine. Tier 3 — OSINT strike-count series and unmanned-systems trackers: the hardest numbers (strikes observed $\neq$ units produced). Claimed capacity figures (6–10M drones/yr) and course-of-production estimates (~4.5M in 2026) are quoted as claims, at aggregate level only.

Equity price observations. Tanker positions vs. 52-week highs (INSW, FRO, TNK at or near highs; STNG ~10% below) as of the 2026-08-24 close, from exchange quote data.

Operational-security rule, applied. This note aggregates deliberately published state messaging and already-public Western analysis into a market-odds frame. Four limits bound the draft: no geolocation of Ukrainian facilities (satellite thermal data in this note points at Russian refineries only); no Ukrainian component suppliers, routes, or workarounds beyond published aggregates; no per-company capacity, location, or bottleneck inference; the capacity-vs-output gap kept aggregate. Sentence-level test: if a hostile reader could act on a sentence here in a way they could not act on its underlying public source, the sentence was cut.

Limitations. All probabilities are market prices carrying the biases of their crowd; the note infers belief from price and says so at each step; the counterfactual named in the steelman (whether restraint itself caps the clash price) is untestable within this frame, as is lever efficacy beyond the 12/31 contract horizon. Prior house work relied upon: the two-path idea spine (`research-ideas/idea-ukraine-two-paths-2026-08-22.md`) and the shadow-fleet ledger (`shadow-fleet-ledger/`).

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